

Sales Training — Session 39

Anchor High. Assume Abundance.

How to Handle "How Much Is It?"

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WHAT THIS SESSION IS What to do when a buyer asks for a price in the first two minutes of the call. The anchor-high move, the Platinum Ranger principle, the "I don't think it's necessary" nudger, the abundance mindset that protects the rep from pre-judging the buyer's wallet, and the broader mental model that the deals are won and lost between the rep's ears before anything ever happens on the call.

1. The question that derails most reps

Inside the first two minutes of almost every prospect call, the buyer asks some version of the same question. "What does this cost?" "How much is it roughly?" "What kind of price are we talking about?" The rep — almost always — flinches. They've been trained to defer pricing until value has been built. They hedge. They try to redirect. They sound evasive. The buyer hears the evasion as something to be suspicious of, and the call gets harder from there.

The session's first move is to reframe what the question actually is. When a buyer asks about price two minutes into a cold call, they're not trying to qualify the product — they don't know enough yet. They're asking themselves a different question: can I afford to keep talking to this person? That's a buying signal, not a refusal. The buyer is testing whether the conversation is worth continuing. The rep who answers cleanly turns the signal into a deal. The rep who hedges loses the call.

"They're asking for the price because they're asking themselves: can I afford this? That's a buying signal. Don't be scared of it. Welcome it."

2. Anchor high — the Platinum Ranger move

The central tactical move of the session. When the buyer asks for the price, the rep doesn't drop a single number. They drop a range — anchored deliberately at the high end. "It really depends on the campaign — we've got clients who spend up to ten or fifteen thousand a month with us. For your situation, I don't think we need anywhere near that." The first number out of the rep's mouth is "15,000." The second number is the calibration down. The buyer's brain, in those two beats, has done all the work the rep needed it to do.

Why the order matters. Imagine the buyer's expectation as a balloon — full of air at whatever number they were assuming the agency might quote. A typical buyer assumes a low number — \$300, maybe \$500. If the rep opens with that range, the balloon stays small. If the rep opens with "up to \$15k for premium clients," the balloon inflates immediately. When the rep then deflates it down to "\$450 to \$650 for your situation," the buyer feels relief. The same number that would have felt expensive now feels reasonable, because it's sitting next to "\$15k."

"It can go up to ten or fifteen thousand for our premium clients. For you, I don't think it's necessary — probably somewhere between \$450 and \$650 a month based on what I'm seeing."

This is the Platinum Ranger principle. Ford doesn't sell most of its Platinum Rangers — they sell the Sport, the model below it. But the Platinum exists on the showroom floor for a reason: it anchors the buyer's expectation upward. The Sport, which the buyer ends up buying, feels reasonable next to the Platinum. Without the Platinum on the floor, the Sport feels like the expensive option. Every car manufacturer knows this. Every car salesperson exploits it. The agency should too.

3. The range — three specific numbers

The anchor isn't a single high number — it's a structured range with three specific data points the rep delivers in sequence. Memorise this shape:

- The floor: "We've got packages from around \$340 a month." The lowest number gives the buyer comfort that there's a low entry point. Don't dwell on it — name it and move on.
- The ceiling: "Some clients spend up to \$10,000 or \$15,000 a month with us — that's our premium tier." The high anchor. Say it confidently. Let it sit in the air for a moment.
- The likely range: "For your business, based on what I'm seeing, I'd allow somewhere between \$450 and \$650 a month." The actual quote. By the time the rep gets here, the buyer has already done the comparison work in their head.

Notice what's happening structurally. The rep has given the buyer a ladder. They know what cheap looks like, what expensive looks like, and where they personally sit on the ladder. The buyer is no longer making a price decision in a vacuum — they're calibrated. And the rep gave them the calibration deliberately, in the order that produces the desired outcome.

"We've got packages from \$340. Some clients spend up to \$15,000. For your business, I'd allow somewhere between \$450 and \$650. Please don't hold me to that — I'd need to look properly — but that's where I'd sit you at this stage."

4. "I don't think it's necessary" — the nudger

A specific phrase worth treating as core toolkit. After the high anchor lands, the rep walks the buyer downward — and the phrase that does the walking is "I don't think it's necessary." It accomplishes three things at once. It signals competence — the rep has assessed and decided the buyer doesn't need the premium package. It signals integrity — the rep isn't trying to upsell into the most expensive tier. And it signals that the rep is on the buyer's side, which is the position from which every easier conversation flows.

Use cases throughout the call:

- "We did one for \$1,250 the other week — but I don't think that's necessary for you."

- "We could go up to \$10–15k for full premium — I don't think it's necessary in your situation."
- "The \$340 entry package exists — but honestly, I don't think it's necessary either. You'd be too thin on activity for it to work properly."

Each use builds the same impression: this rep is recommending what the buyer actually needs, not what would generate the largest commission. That's a posture buyers respect, and it's a posture that closes more deals than any aggressive upsell ever does.

5. The balloon model — inflate, then deflate

A mental image worth carrying into every pricing conversation. The buyer's mental price expectation is a balloon. Whatever the rep says first inflates or deflates that balloon. The rep's deliberate move is to inflate the balloon early in the conversation (with the high anchor), then deflate it down to where the deal actually sits.

Reps who get this wrong make one of two mistakes. They open with a low or middle number, leaving the balloon unstretched — the buyer has no high comparison point, and the middle number feels like the expensive option. Or they refuse to give any number at all ("we'd need to discuss it in a meeting first"), leaving the buyer's balloon to inflate on its own to whatever scary figure their imagination produces. Both mistakes lose deals. The discipline is to inflate the balloon deliberately, with a number you choose, and then walk it down to the number you actually want.

"Inflate the buyer's expectation deliberately. Then walk it down to the price you actually want. The exact same number feels expensive next to \$100 and feels reasonable next to \$15,000."

6. The Lotus Emura story — what pre-judging costs

A long worked example from Corie's own life, used to make a specific point about assumption. Corie went to a prestige car dealership to buy a Lotus Emura. He was wearing his usual tracksuit. The Lotus salesperson — distracted by two well-dressed young women he'd been chatting with — looked at Corie's clothes, made a snap judgement, and decided this customer wasn't worth real attention. When Corie asked to test-drive the car, the salesperson demanded a \$1,000 deposit "to prove you're serious" before unlocking the keys. Corie walked out and bought a Ford Ranger from a different dealer the same day.

The Ford salesperson had made the opposite assumption. He matched Corie's energy, agreed to the price on the spot, took a \$500 deposit, and closed the deal in fifteen minutes. Same buyer. Same money in the bank. Two completely different sales experiences — and the difference was the assumption each salesperson made about Corie's wealth based on what he was wearing. The Lotus salesperson lost a six-figure sale because he pre-judged the wallet.

"Same customer. Same wallet. The Ford guy assumed I had the money and closed in fifteen minutes. The Lotus guy assumed I didn't and lost a six-figure deal. The only variable was the assumption."

The application to the team is direct. Every prospect call carries the same risk. The rep can't see the buyer's actual financial position. They're guessing — and the guess shapes the entire call before the rep has said anything price-related at all. A rep who unconsciously assumes "this buyer probably can't afford much" pitches differently from a rep who assumes "this buyer probably has plenty of money." The first rep loses deals they could have closed. The second rep wins deals the first rep would have walked away from.

7. Don't say dumb things. Don't THINK dumb things either.

An extension of a principle that's appeared across multiple sessions, sharpened here. "Don't say dumb things" is half of the rule. The other half — equal in importance and often overlooked — is don't THINK dumb things. Because if a rep thinks the buyer is broke before the buyer has said a word, the assumption leaks into the call's tone, the pace, the pricing language, the willingness to hold the line. Buyers can hear assumptions through the phone. They can't articulate it, but they feel it. And they react accordingly.

This is why the price conversation is fought between the rep's ears before it's fought with the buyer. A rep with the wrong internal assumption is starting the call at a disadvantage that no script can correct. A rep with the right internal assumption — that the buyer has resources, has a real problem, and is genuinely open to spending if the value is there — can recover from minor verbal slips that the wrong-assumption rep can't.

"You can only make it worse — by saying dumb things, or thinking dumb things. Both leak into the call. Both lose deals. The thinking happens before the speaking — so the thinking is where the discipline has to live."

8. Assume abundance — the default is loaded

The corrective frame the session offered. Default assumption, every call, regardless of evidence: the buyer has abundant resources. They have a real problem worth solving. They have the money to solve it. The agency's job is to find the right solution for them. The rep is not their financial advisor — the rep is not there to decide what the buyer can or can't afford. The rep is there to present what's available and let the buyer make their own decision.

This isn't optimism — it's an operational discipline. The downside of assuming the buyer is rich and being wrong is small (you've pitched a middle-tier option to someone who would have only afforded the floor, and they tell you and you adjust). The downside of assuming the buyer is broke and being wrong is enormous (you've pitched a small option and gotten a small deal — or no deal — from someone who would have happily spent five times more). The asymmetric risk runs in only one direction. Bet that way.

"Assume the buyer has loads of money and has a problem. Those are the two assumptions. Anything else is you guessing — and guessing only costs you. Bet the way that has upside."

9. Match the buyer's energy

A specific tonal discipline. Some buyers want a long, methodical conversation — they're processing slowly, they want detail, they need to talk through the implications. Some buyers want speed — they've decided they want the thing, they need a number and a path, they don't want to be walked through the agency's value proposition for the eleventh time. The rep's job is to read which buyer they have, and match.

The Ford Super Duty story makes the principle concrete. When Corie rang the dealer in Yorke Peninsula and asked for the price, the salesperson named it — "\$105k" — and Corie asked for \$100k flat. The dealer said "yes" within sixty seconds. The whole transaction took five minutes. Why? Because the dealer read the buyer's energy correctly: this was a buyer who didn't want to be sold to, he wanted to buy. The dealer matched the energy, named the deal, took the deposit. Six-figure sale in five minutes.

Reps who don't match energy lose buyers like Corie every week. The buyer wants speed; the rep slows them down with the standard pitch. The buyer disengages — not because the product was wrong, but because the salesperson didn't read the room. Match the buyer's pace. If they want details, give details. If they want a price, give a price. Don't impose the same script on every buyer because that's what the script says.

"Match the buyer's energy. Some want speed. Some want detail. Don't force every buyer through the same pitch — read them and adapt."

10. Don't judge by what they say. Judge by what they do.

One of the most counter-intuitive but reliable principles in the session. The buyer who's verbally enthusiastic — "this is wonderful, I love what you're doing, you're brilliant" — is often not buying. The buyer who's flat, terse, and price-focused — "how much, what's included, when does it ship" — is often a real deal. The polite enthusiasm is what people use when they want to let the rep down gently. The flat tone is what people use when they're concentrating on a transaction they intend to complete.

This is hard to internalise because it inverts the rep's emotional feedback loop. The polite buyer feels great to talk to. The transactional buyer feels cold and possibly rude. The rep's instinct is to spend MORE time on the polite one and try to close the warmer call — and they'll spend less time on the cold one because it's uncomfortable. Both instincts are backwards. The warm call is usually a long goodbye. The cold call is usually a real deal in progress.

"Don't judge people by what they say. Judge by what they do. The buyer who's complimenting you is often saying goodbye. The buyer who's asking for the price is buying."

Practical move: when a call feels too warm — when the buyer is laying it on thick about how brilliant the rep is — the rep should ask for the next step IMMEDIATELY. "So can I send through the paperwork now?" The polite buyer will reveal themselves with a soft retreat ("oh, well, I'll need to think about it, talk to my partner"). The real buyer will say yes. The test is fast and clean.

11. The buyer's side — least info, most leverage

A useful reframe from the buyer's perspective. When the rep is in buying mode (buying a car, a house, a service), their job is to give the seller the least information possible. They don't want to telegraph their budget. They don't want to reveal their urgency. They want to extract the lowest price by appearing as uncommitted as possible. This is what good buyers do — universally — and the rep should recognise it when buyers do it to them.

Corie's worked example: when he bought his current house, he negotiated by making it clear he didn't need the property, gave the sellers a specific (low) price, and explicitly said "no pressure, take as long as you want to think about it." The seller, faced with a buyer who appeared genuinely uninterested in pushing for a deal, eventually accepted a 30% discount on the listed price. The "no pressure" was the leverage — it told the seller this buyer wasn't going to chase, which meant the seller had to.

Applied to selling: when a rep's buyer is being uncommunicative, slow to respond, or non-committal, the rep should recognise this as buyer-side behaviour — they're trying to extract a better price by appearing uninterested. The correct response isn't to chase harder (which gives them the leverage they're trying to create). It's to remain calm, name the deal cleanly, and wait. The rep who chases loses. The rep who's willing to walk usually wins.

"As a buyer, my job is to give you the least information. As a seller, your job is to extract the most. The buyer who feels nonchalant is usually the buyer who's about to spend."

12. Asymmetric bets — only one direction has downside

Pulling the threads together. The session's deeper principle is that the rep should structure every decision so the downside is bounded and the upside is open. Asymmetric bets — the kind where you win all the way.

Examples from the session:

- Anchor high → if it lands, you sell premium; if it doesn't, you walk down. Only upside.
- Assume abundance → if right, you pitch confidently; if wrong, the buyer corrects you with a real number. Only upside.
- Show up with the right attitude → if it's a good day, the attitude helps; if it's a bad day, the attitude is the only thing keeping you in the game. Only upside.

- Assume the call you're on now is the deal → you'll run the process properly; even if it isn't the deal, the next one might be, and you've practised. Only upside.

The session's framing: the rep's job isn't to be right about every individual call. The rep's job is to position themselves where being wrong on any individual call still produces forward motion. Asymmetry compounds. Reps who structure their decisions this way win across a year even when they lose on individual days.

"Position yourself so there's no downside. That's asymmetric. The deals come from accumulating asymmetric bets over a year, not from being right about any single call."

13. The Broadway show — same performance, every audience

A closing image. Broadway performers don't adjust their performance based on the size of the crowd, the mood of the audience, or how engaged the front row looks. They give the same performance every night because the performance is the discipline. The audience does its job; the performer does theirs. Reps who try to read the audience and adjust the performance in real-time end up with neither a consistent performance nor an audience that's particularly happy.

Applied to the desk: show up with the same energy on call number one and call number thirty. Don't let the rude buyer at 11am make the polite buyer at 3pm pay for it. Don't let the closer at 9am make the difficult buyer at 4pm benefit from coasting. Every call deserves the same performance. The rep who can hold this — across a day, across a week, across a year — is the rep who builds a career.

"Same performance, one seat or a thousand. That's the discipline. The audience does its job; you do yours. Don't adjust the show based on the crowd."

14. Action items for the team

1. Memorise the three-number range: floor ("340"), ceiling ("10–15k"), likely ("450–650 for your business"). Practise saying it aloud until it lands smoothly without hesitation.
2. Add "I don't think it's necessary" to your verbal toolbox. Use it at least three times in the next five calls — once on the premium tier, once on the floor, once on a feature the buyer doesn't need.
3. Before every prospect call, mentally state out loud: "This buyer has loads of money and a real problem." Two assumptions. Hold them until the buyer's own words prove otherwise.
4. When you catch yourself thinking "they probably can't afford this," name it — "that's me pre-judging the wallet" — and reset. The thinking precedes the speaking. The discipline has to live in the thinking.
5. On your next five calls, deliberately match the buyer's pace. If they want speed, give it. If they want detail, give it. Don't impose the same pitch on every buyer.

6. When a buyer feels TOO warm — too complimentary, too enthusiastic — ask for the next step immediately. Test whether the warmth is real with one clean question. Polite buyers will reveal themselves.
7. If a buyer goes quiet or non-committal mid-call, stop chasing. Name the deal cleanly and wait. The buyer-side behaviour usually breaks first when the rep refuses to chase.
8. End each day asking yourself: did I make any asymmetric bets today? If every choice you made had downside on both sides, you weren't positioning yourself well. Bet the way that has upside-only.

THE RULE OF THUMB Anchor high. Walk down with "I don't think it's necessary." Assume the buyer has loads of money and a real problem. Don't pre-judge the wallet. Match their energy. Judge by what they do, not what they say. Same performance, every audience. The pricing battle is fought between your ears before it's fought on the call — win it there first.